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# Investing in knowledge institutions

The safe strategy in public policy is to incrementally evolve—making small moves, obtaining feedback from the empirical evidence, and refining policy work in response to evidence. This process requires the construction of trusted data sets. It also requires intellectual capabilities in analysing this information and feeding knowledge back into the policy process.

It is generally difficult to recruit these analytical capabilities into the Indian state. The two worlds—main-line civil servant vs intellectual capabilities—are far apart in terms of organizational culture and recruitment profile. In the long run, this should change. The ultimate aim of a knowledge society is an arrangement where all government intervention is grounded in a research process.

But for many years, we may expect that the organizational DNA in the state is not conducive to recruiting researchers or to creating the conditions in which they can be productive. Under these conditions, it is particularly important for Indian government organizations to develop deep partnerships with knowledge institutions.

Policymakers in government tend to be in the din and noise of the day-to-day policy process. The departments of government suffer from a high pace of staffing changes. Government organizations tend to defend the prevailing policy positions, which is not conducive to the intellectual process of understanding many points of view and analysing them dispassionately.

Knowledge institutions have the luxury of not answering Parliament questions, or getting hijacked by the newspaper headlines. This gives an opportunity for sustained focus, over long years, that is required to think